

Esterke — A Reader's Digest of the Dialogue

Aaron Zeitlin, *Esterke* (a four-act Polish-Jewish mystery). A scene-by-scene retelling, voiced speaker by speaker, written alongside the errata pass.

A note on what this is: an evocation, not a translation. The lines below are the editor's own paraphrase — an attempt to carry across the *temper* of Zeitlin's verse (its stateliness, its incantation, its bitterness) without reproducing it. Each speaker's lines are given in that speaker's own voice — **I** for the one speaking, **you** for the one addressed — with stage directions and framing kept in the third person. The play is in copyright; no verbatim text is quoted here. Covers the whole play, folios 81–150.

Headings mark dramatic scenes, not book pages; the folio range in each scene heading is only a cross-reference to the errata files (folio = book page = PDF page – 4).

Who's who:

Kazimir — the king; Casimir the Great, weighed down by crown and lineage.

Sukhivilk (Yan) — bishop and Chancellor; the king's steady, lawmaking hand.

Wierzzinek — Kraków councilor and chamberlain; thinks in gold and trade.

Spitek (of Melsztyn) — a lord of the old knightly party; sword over statute.

Baritshka — a zealous priest, later a rebel; speaks for Bishop Bodzanta.

Barkovitsh (Matshko) — a restive noble who dares the king, and worse.

Adelaida — the king's estranged German queen, whom he will not touch.

Levko — the king's Jew; coin-caster, protector of his people.

Esterke — the Jewish girl of Opatshne; the king's beloved, mother of his son Pelko.

Yadviga — princess of Silesia; the king's dancer, all surrender and flame.

Kokhan, Govorek — castle watchmen. **Kokh / Wenceslaus** — the cook; **Zvonka** — the kitchen-maid.

Netsiel — the Eternal Jew, a shadow-figure who haunts the play.

In the epilogue: **Yerukhem** (Esterke's father), a madman, and the poets **Peretz** and **Mickiewicz**.

ACT I

the king's hall

The council: sword or statute (*folios 81–83*)

Setting: the knights' hall in King Kazimir's castle. Present: Bishop Yan Sukhivilk, the Chancellor; Wierzzinek, Kraków councilor and chamberlain; Spitek of Melsztyn, a lord.

Spitek: once again they have denounced us to the Pope in Avignon — slandered Poland to his face.

Sukhivilk: the men of the Cross-Order — the Germans?

Spitek: yes, they! How much longer shall Łokietek's sword rust in its sheath?

Sukhivilk: Łokietek found Poland lying on the battlefield, carried her home naked, covered only with a bare sword. Poor was that home — a hut of wood, its roof of straw. And now Kazimir must settle his father's Poland into a walled almshouse.

Spitek: why forever go to law with our enemies before the Pope's holy chair? Is Łokietek's sword not the best answer of all?

Sukhivilk: Poland needs rest now, if she is to grow great. And she needs justice.

Wierzzinek: Poland's enemies are cunning — let them be beaten not by the sword but by cunning. The foe is too small, the land too great in the shadow of Kazimir's hand. It is not wars we need now. Prosperity — to people the towns — ducats — trade.

Sukhivilk: and law, Wierzzinek.

Spitek: leave gold and trade to Levko, the king's Jew. There is only one right here worth the name: the knights' right.

Sukhivilk: the sun of justice must shine equally upon all.

Spitek: upon serf and Jew as well?

Sukhivilk: we need written laws — one statute, equal, for all the lands of Poland.

Spitek: unheard of! Each land in Poland has its own right; each knight his own —

Wierzzinek: Spitek, that is ill said — and the king's own chamberlain tells you so.

Spitek: as it has been, so it must remain.

Sukhivilk: it will not remain. When all stand equal before the king's throne, Poland will become Poland. And if not — then we hold not Poland, but only shreds of her.

Wierzzinek: clever words, Bishop Yan. They will ring as golden coin in the coffers, for law is gold — and what does gold do? It raises towers, builds fortress-towns — what does it not?

Spitek: Kraków councilor, king's chamberlain — you dream of gold. But we, the knights, need iron, need the sword, not clever pacts and sly litigation. Only battle makes a land strong, and battle keeps it. One thing more: I hear the knights are gathering here — they mean to fetch down the queen and raise an uproar, and the church lends its hand. The Teutons' heart rejoices betimes. To spite them all, Kazimir ought to be reconciled with his wife.

The king, and the priest's warning (*folios 84–88*)

Spitek: — why else do the enemies grow so bold? (Kazimir enters; all bow their heads.) The foes are small, and Poland's king¹ is great.

¹ Footnote in the source — *krol* (Polish for “king”) = *melekh* (Hebrew for “king”).

Kazimir: why do you flatter me?

Spitek: you are great, I said — and that is true. But you shun war too much — and that is true as well.

Kazimir: a land has been entrusted to me — Łokietek's inheritance. I make my pacts, I increase its plenty, I build and I wall; let the peasant's toil rise up in peace, and let the unjust man not go unpunished.

Sukhivilk: gladly do I help you. And should knighthood or church set itself against you, I set myself against whoever opposes. Strong must Kazimir be — Poland's king.

Kazimir: strong must Kazimir be, Poland's king — yet there is another Kazimir in me, and that one too wants a happiness of his own.

Wierzzinek: has a king any right to a happiness of his own?

Sukhivilk: your word shone so brightly just now — do not cloud your own word.

Spitek: whoever wills happiness for Poland must forget his own. A ruler must fight; too long there has been no war. It is well for the peasant — he plows and he sows — but a *peasant-king* is what Łokietek's son becomes, and he leads us not to battle.

(Father Baritshka appears, a crucifix in his hand.)

Spitek: Father Baritshka comes!

Baritshka: praised be Jesus Christ!²

² Footnote in the source — Baritshka's greeting is Polish: “praised be [Jesus Christ]”.

All: in all eternities — amen.

Baritshka: in the name of the King over kings, of Christ the crucified —

Kazimir: what brings you to my threshold?

Baritshka: your wickedness.

Kazimir: is that how you speak to your lord?

Baritshka: my lord is he who hangs there upon the cross.

Kazimir: what is it you want?

Baritshka: he warns you through me, his young servant — through Bodzanta, father of the church.

Kazimir: why does he not come himself?

Baritshka: you have offended him.

Kazimir: so his messenger comes to offend me in return?

Baritshka: is it an offense to say that my lord is not you, but the Crucified? Your name thunders over Hungary and Rus; but as great as your rule and your cleverness are — greater still are your sins. And so the word of God's wrath goes out against you. It is no secret to the church that Łokietek's son squanders his strength on foreign women, while the wife whose bond with him the church itself hallowed sits forsaken and alone in Zsharnovitse castle. I know — you build cloisters; but does Jesus dwell in your heart? Women dwell there.

Wierzzinek: so long as gold dwells in the coffers, what do I care what women dwell in the king's heart — provided they are not of Jewish stock?

Sukhivilk: Baritshka, you forget that you stand before the man who is one with Poland. I am a bishop, as you know — but I am also the king's Chancellor. How do *you* know what the Crucified desires? How does Bodzanta know? Hearing you speak, it seems to me the Crucified desires rather to step down — to go away from you and your kind —

Baritshka: you are a liar and a traitor. The church has no need of you.

Sukhivilk: Poland has need of me.

Spitek: the knights say it too: the king dallies with women of every sort, and wants no child of his own wife. Will a grandchild of Łokietek's ever come after him to Poland's throne?

Baritshka: hear me, Kazimir: turn your heart from concubines. You follow the lust of sinful eyes.

Kazimir: what do you know, and what do you understand? Can you know, you fool, what drives me — your ruler — from woman to woman?

Baritshka: what drives a man's heart from woman to woman — if not the dark Adversary himself? Understand this: I have not come here alone. Knights, servants of Jesus, who stand on the side of the cloister, have come here with me.

Spitek: it is not for nothing, this uproar before the castle. I hear the voice of Barkovitsh.

Kazimir: who — that Matshko? Does he too speak in the name of the Crucified? Baritshka — Bodzanta has already sent *you*.

Baritshka: surely. But is Barkovitsh, then, no Christian?

Sukhivilk: do you mean you will crucify the king? Conspirators' heads are fond of tumbling from their shoulders.

Wierzszinek: well said. What is it to me with whom the krol passes his time, so long as the women are Christian daughters!

Baritshka: we have no fear for our heads, Sukhivilk; we fear God alone. The king sins.

Spitek: because he loves his peace. It is war we lack. From idleness all sins grow.

The unwanted queen (*folios 89–92*)

Baritshka: a woman has come in with the knights — your own cast-off wife, my king, Adelaida, fetched here unbidden from the castle at Zsharnovitse.

Kazimir: who dared bring her? I'll have you clapped in irons for it!

Baritshka: chain me, then — God rides with me.

Spitek: for her sake, hold — is she not the queen, the one who shares your very crown?

Kazimir: for thirteen years she has shared neither my crown nor my bed. Behind her loom the German landgraves, the knights who are Poland's enemies — shall I let my father's old foes climb to power through her body? To my father's shade I owe a reckoning, and I mean to pay it.

(Adelaida is borne in on the tide of the crowd, pale and unsure.)

Baritshka (to her): down — kneel to your husband and king! Has the church not blessed this bond? Let the sight of your face wake his heart — if a heart is still in him.

Adelaida (kneeling, to Kazimir): torment me no more, I beg you. You keep me shut in your fist — open your hand, and let me flit free over it, a little bird.

Kazimir: I know — you have pined for me for years.

Adelaida: thirteen years I have hoped. These eyes, these lips that no one has kissed, are yours and yours alone.

Kazimir: wife's servility — this sorrow of the enslaved! Do you even know what you are in your masters' hands?

Adelaida: I know only this — that you owe me a child.

Kazimir: out of knightly grace I might have forced myself to love you — but your father and all Poland's enemies reach through you toward my inheritance. To give you a child would be to sell that inheritance to traitors. I hate your father, the German landgrave.

Adelaida: nothing to me, father or enemies — it is *you* I need, only you.

Kazimir: you weary me — a slave, like every woman. Better your father make good the gold he promised: two thousand kopes of Polish groschen. All these years, and still he keeps no word.

Baritshka (to her): you trifle like a pagan. The church names you his wife — obey you must.

Adelaida: I will go. But through the long nights, to the lonely daybreaks, I will lie listening — for whether my lord turns back to me.

Adelaida: my heart will go on asking forever. (She goes out slowly, one last look thrown behind her.)

Spitek: that — that was the queen herself, and she stood there begging.

Kazimir: just so — my queen begs love of me as a beggar begs a coin.

Kokhan (bursting in): a storm outside, my king — the crowd in full roar, and one voice climbing over all the rest.

Kazimir: let that Matshko come in.

Matshko Barkovitsh (entering, bowing low): my head bows low before you, ruler.

Kazimir: why all this bellowing at my gate?

Barkovitsh: no bellowing — I merely said a thing.

Barkovitsh's challenge; the doors flung open (*folios 93–94*)

Kazimir: and what did you say?

Barkovitsh: shall Kazimir be the last of the Piasts? Where is his heir? Why has he cast out his wife once more?

Kazimir: are you not my councilor — free to speak in the king's council? Who is it that sets the knights against me?

Barkovitsh: others do that — not I. I am loyal.

Kazimir: your falseness I know well. I remember your old revolt — against Wierzbiet, against me. I remember it still. Take care.

(Barkovitsh bows his head.)

Kazimir (shouting for the watchmen): fling wide every door and gate — let them all come in!

(The watchmen obey; the hall floods with knights.)

Kazimir: bring me the princess lodged in my castle — say the king calls!

Spitek: what will the king do?

Wierzszinek: he has thrown the doors open to the mutiny with his own hands.

Sukhivilk: fear nothing — the king knows his own business.

Kazimir (to the sullen crowd): you mice, gnawing at my throne — would you gnaw my heart as well? To spite you all, I will have Yadviga, princess of Silesia, dance out her love before your eyes.

Yadviga (led in, all abasement): praise to the king! I kiss his dust. What does my lord command?

Kazimir: "your lord"... now stand, smile, look.

Yadviga's dance (*folios 95–96*)

Yadviga: I smile as you will it, my king; I look with as many eyes as you wish. Your will is my whole law.

Kazimir: every one of them the same — "my lord," "the king."

(The knights praise her by turns:) **Sukhivilk:** she flashes! — **Wierzszinek:** like the purest gold in a rich man's hoard. — **Spitek:** like a bright warrior's mail. — **Sukhivilk:** like the Vistula drinking down the whole sun before nightfall.

Barkovitsh (aside, half-aloud): when *I* am king —

Kazimir (cutting him off): meanwhile *I* am king. Dance, Yadviga — that dance you love to give me. Care nothing that strangers watch: Matshko and his pack are no one at all, nothing, not even here.

Yadviga (eyes shut, arms flung open, hair unbound): my beloved is a lion.

Yadviga (singing as she dances): to the lion I give my body, and gladly; my love is the strongest and most valiant of men, the envy of women, with the mighty lips of a king who drinks the finest wines — I am his, only his. (She drops, spent, at the king's feet.)

Kazimir: does she please you, Barkovitsh — a fine thing, is she not?

(Barkovitsh gives no answer.)

Kazimir: my thanks, Yadviga. You may go back — stand up and go.

Yadviga (rising): my mighty one! My lord! (She goes out without a glance.)

Kazimir: you would have wanted one like her, Barkovitsh? No — and why so silent now, Matshko?

"A man hunted by women" (*folios 97–98*)

Barkovitsh (starting to speak, then biting it back): I'd have — ... no. (Laughter.)

Kazimir: why do I keep her shut in the castle? Because she came offering me her love and will not leave. And this same Kazimir you whisper of — who supposedly seduced the Hungarian court-girl Klara and, for her sake, wiped out her whole house — this Kazimir has had the loveliest women running at his heels: Aldona the Lithuanian heathen, Adelaida the German margrave's daughter. Beautiful, every one — and every one sang me the same song Yadviga just danced. From cast-off Adelaida to Yadviga of Liegnitz, they have all gaped at me like fawning dogs — *king, ruler, strongest of men* — and I loathe them for their very slavishness. It burns in you too, Baritshka, with the lusts of a monkish ascetic; and you, Barkovitsh, are eaten with a seething envy. What do the two of you know of Kazimir the Second — no lord, no king, no woman-chaser, but a man *hunted* by women? I feast my eye on their splendor, I bid them dance, I revel — but when the bed is made I do not lie down with them. I wait — for whom, I cannot say. Either she must be strong as I am, or else innocent as a child; and not one of these can be the mother of my heir — not one.

Sukhivilk: you name yourself a child of lust — then kneel to your ruler and beg his pardon.

Barkovitsh: yes — but a king must have an heir. Must he not, my lords?

Voices: he must. Matshko has the right of it.

Sukhivilk (to the king): are you ready, O king, to be the last of your house — the last of the Piasts?

Kazimir: I am ready. — (Kokhan enters.)

The Jews at the gate: the Po-lin legend (*folios 99–103*)

Kokhan: men of the Jewish people, in tall hats and sashes, parchments in hand, bow and seek you, my king — led by Levko the coin-caster.

Kazimir: let them in.

Spitek: they flood in thicker and thicker, these Jews — an ill wind blows them from the Swabian lands, from Bohemia, from everywhere; they conjure spells, they drop poison in the wells —

Barkovitsh: — and Poland does not cast out those the Swabians drove off for their sorcerer's pact with *her*, the Black Death.

Baritshka: Kazimir lets in more and more of these Christ-killers, who crucified Jesus. Woe to us.

Wierzszinek: the castle-lords watch their coming uneasily; the townsfolk are less pleased still.

Sukhivilk: and with what, then, is Poland ever pleased, councilor?

Kazimir: we shall have statutes drawn up, Yan — at Wiślica; statutes for Jews as well, rights set down on strong parchment.

Spitek: Bolesław of Kalisz already blessed their kind with charters — the ones who came before and stuffed their sacks with Polish gold.

Sukhivilk: shall we renew and confirm the Jews' rights?

Baritshka: there is no right for those who crucified our God. O Jesus — you look on, and you keep silent!

(The Jews enter, Levko at their head.)

Kazimir (to Levko): what does the Jew wish — this servant of my chamber?

Levko: I bring you tribute, my king, gathered from your servants the Jews; and I have brought Jews this time who wish to speak with you.

Rabbi: praised be He who shares of His glory with flesh and blood — (the other Jews echo the blessing) — fugitives from the sword, we have fallen...

Rabbi: ...to the kind body of Poland's earth. *Po-lin — here, lodge!* so an angel said, when one night we fugitives came with wife and child upon your fields. The ground still shuddered under our feet, as though we had just stepped from a ship of demons; it seemed the night was whetting black knives, that evil winds throttled the sleeping birds and reached for our children too. Then a cloud opened above us and split in two, and out of its heart, rocking on a cord of lightning, an angel pointed with a silver finger: *Po-lin — here lodge the night!* And it fell still, and as through the ancient gates of Canaan we came into the land by morning. (Silence.)

Kazimir: a wondrous tale, old man. But why only *lodge* a night? Your brothers have passed more than one night on my earth already.

Rabbi: it is written — a thousand years are in Your eyes as a yesterday gone by, a watch in the night. So too is the night of the people Israel: let our exile's night run a thousand years upon your lands — it is but a single night, O king.

Rabbi: ...until the day of Jerusalem dawns anew, we lodge here one night — those come before, and we who come now, hounded by malice and blood-libel.
Po-lin — here, lodge!

Spitek: the Jews are shrewd; they know how to invent.

Baritshka: if the crown shelters them, the holy cross will give them no rest.

Barkovitsh: cross and crown must go as one.

Voices: true, true!

Sukhivilk: if the cross sets itself against the crown, then the crown must stand against the cross.

Baritshka: false shepherd!

Levko (to the king): we thrive here in the shadow of the princes. Bolesław of Kalisz gave us charters, protection for our goods — (he hands you the parchments) — with your royal seal we beg you seal that old writ anew. As I, your Levko, am your Jew and your protected man, so shield them all, the fugitives — the newcomers to your land; they are all yours. We are the king's, for we are not understood, as a king is not understood. Lonely is Israel.

Kazimir (taken by the thought): not understood, as a king is not understood... lonely as a king — and so you belong to the king. Go with God, and be comforted; I will give you my protection, you lonely ones.

Rabbi: may the God of Sinai not forget you this mercy.

Wierzzinek: the Jew-eyes glitter; the king's heart is being lulled.

Spitek: not good, Wierzzinek — not good.

Levko (to the king): woe will come to Poland's people if you torment the folk that God Himself scattered and in His mercy will gather in; your people is set here as a trial.

Kazimir: I understand. (A weeping drifts in from beyond the windows.) Who weeps there at my windows?

Levko: my king — for a Jewish daughter I plead.

Esterke enters; the curse, and the Eternal Jew (*folios 104–108*)

Levko: barefoot she ran after us, weeping the whole road, and weeps yet; your servants will not let her in.

Kazimir: bring her to me! Angels must weep so, if angels weep at all.

Spitek: so weep false Jewish daughters.

Wierzzinek (aside to Sukhivilk): who now guards the king's heart?

Barkovitsh: my lords — a new stormcloud rolls your way.

Baritshka: the cross in my hand will drive her off.

(Esterke enters weeping, her face hidden behind her hands.)

Kazimir (to her): hands over your face... luminous hands... take them away — show yourself!

Spitek (running to the girl): no — do not take them away! If your face is as fair as your form, you will bewitch the king, you child of the sorcerer-folk.

Kazimir (to Esterke): I am waiting. (She lowers her hands.)

(Esterke trembles, and lets her hands fall from her face.)

Sukhivilk: the sun has shown itself — and what bird would not bathe in it?

Kazimir: what are you called?

Esterke: Esterke. I am from Opotshne. My mother is no longer living — my birth was her death. My father had only me, and an inn. Pashko, lord of the village, wanted to take me from my father; my father would not give me up, and I would not go — I hid. So Pashko had the inn burned, and my father with it. I fled; his men could not find me. I ran to Poland's king, to fall before his throne and cry for justice — and on the road I fell in with Jews, and followed them.

Kazimir: Pashko shall be punished — I'll have him dragged here in chains. But tell me, daughter: why would you not stay with Pashko?

Rabbi: she is a Jewish daughter, king — should she deny the faith of the fathers?

Kazimir (to Esterke): and when I, your king, say — stay with me? When I — (Esterke is silent.)

Sukhivilk: the king's heart trembles in the net — and waits —

Wierzzzinek: it is happening — oh, calamity!

Spitek: calamity! it is sorcery —

Rabbi: God forbid — apostasy —

The other Jews: our only one... woe to us... apostasy, God forbid...

Levko: Esther is her name — why not, then, a second Esther? Let her too shield her people, stand up for her brothers. Truly — it would be a fine thing.

Kazimir (to Esterke): answer me! When your king bids you *be with me* — would you flee from me too?

Esterke: yes. I hate the strong.

Rabbi (low, to the Jews around him)...

Rabbi (softly): praised be God —

Levko: you foolish child!

Wierzzzinek: ha — she still does not please him! What do you say, Spitek?

Spitek: I say — let her flee now, at once, the sooner the better!

Barkovitsh (his eye fixed on her): too beautiful, she is... too beautiful. The greatest knight might take her for a concubine — and then wring the head from her neck.

Kazimir (to Esterke): you hate the strong... look at me. Look, and be still. What do you see? (A pause.)

Esterke: you are not merry. Are the strong, then, also not merry? Can evil even be done to the wicked?

Kazimir: one who has everything is as forsaken, Esterke, as one who has nothing. It is the strong who are wicked — not the strongest.

Esterke (as if surfacing from a dream): he speaks... I do not know what comes over me... the walls draw apart... I see no one... only him... (she takes a few steps toward the king).

Sukhivilk (to no one): my king's dream... the longed-for woman... the child... the innocence... Is the dream good, is the dream ill? Who can know?

Kazimir: only you and I... only you and I... it is growing light...

Baritshka (to the king): be accursed as Judas! Be accursed!

Sukhivilk: you blaspheme the king of Poland! (calling) Watchmen — bind him!

(Baritshka is bound; Barkovitsh and the knights withdraw; Spitek and Wierzzzinek fall to whispering. A phantom shadows into the hall.)

Netsiel, the Eternal Jew (to the audience): with shadow-staff and shadow-foot, in my hollow gait, so have I come striding here into Poland. I, the Jew Netsiel, stand behind their backs. They will play their parts for me — and I will watch. (The curtain falls swiftly.)

ACT II

the courtyard, over Baritshka's pit

Two clowns at the pit (*folios 109–110*)

Setting: a corner of the royal courtyard; stone steps down to a walled pit capped with a round iron lid. Two watchmen — **Kokhan** and **Govorek** — loom on the lowest step, halberds in hand, lanterns smoking at their feet. Two grotesque figures approach: **Pastekhl**, the shepherd-boy with a whip, and **Zkndl**, a broad mushroom-headed old man on trembling legs, trailing after.

Pastekhl (whistling, cracking his whip): old groaner — where are you bound?

Zkndl: to Esterke, in the king's castle.

Pastekhl: so am I.

Zkndl: good-dream, prankster, piper, liar!

Pastekhl: bad-dream, old fretter, trembling-leg!

Zkndl: whip-cracker, caper-cutter, know-not-what, cheat!

Pastekhl: truth-teller, truth-mourner, croucher, old radish!

Zkndl: young petak!³

³ Footnote in the source — *petak* (accent on the first syllable) = a fool.

Pastekhl: young am I as Esterke — a whole herd of phantoms I drive out to pasture.

Zkndl: and what will come of it later, you good-for-nothing?

Pastekhl: later-shmater, sour uncle! Let me run — you crawl after! (Both off.)

Govorek (to Kokhan): as if that one could so much as bark! You're a dog — then bark! A guard — then guard! A churchman — then pray! And a ruler — then rule! But when the churchman foment — into the pit with him! Though, truth be told, only the Church may sit in judgment on him.

Kokhan: ever since Sukhivilk had him locked up here to await judgment, he lies on a bundle of straw, crossing himself, and never stops cursing our gracious king.

Govorek: well — that too is only right. If a man's been wronged, let him not keep silent, brother. Let him curse!

The watchmen's whispered treason; the king at the pit (*folios 111–112*)

Kokhan: bread and water are let down to you — say thank you. Would you be a holy man? Then be one — only leave the ruler be. Does God want you to blaspheme a king?

Govorek: the king ought to have set him free, brother Kokhan. Sukhivilk wishes it now too. But — little brother — it cannot be done.

Kokhan: so the king and Sukhivilk together can't manage the little thing you and I could —

Govorek: you mean — a bolt across the lid here, and it's finished? No. The knights who stand against our gracious king only wait for Baritshka to be freed — then they'd make *him* shorter by a head, and never ask; they'd say Kazimir murdered the servant of the Lord Jesus.

Kokhan: you're talking in your sleep!

Govorek: it's folly, I know. But I tell you: shorter by a head — understand? And the head would come rolling up onto our own king's shoulders. The things you hear!

Kokhan: you're making it up.

Govorek: I heard it myself, in the courtyard. We used to guard one way; now we guard another — now we guard so the king's own enemies can't kill him.

Kokhan: a keg of water — time to lower it into the pit. (unbolting, bending over) hey — thirsty, father Baritshka? (He lowers a keg on a rope; from below rises Baritshka's shriek of a curse; Kokhan bolts it shut again. On the steps a silhouette appears — the king, pale, disheveled, nightlike. The watchmen bow; Kazimir comes down.)

Kazimir: what is he doing?

Kokhan: does my gracious one permit us to ask what he does? He lies and curses. We do not let him die — water, bread — and his answer is curses.

Kazimir: unbolt it! (The pit is opened; the king steps close.) Baritshka! Do you not know who speaks? The king speaks. There is no sleeping, Baritshka.

Baritshka's voice (from the pit): is your bed, too, straw? Go to your Jewish concubine. Ruin on you, Wawel — ruin!

Heaven above, a pit below (*folio 113*)

Kazimir: bolt it shut again! (The pit is barred.) God — what am I doing here? A whole heaven of love above me — Esterke — and here below, a curse. A heaven of love, and a pit. Esterke, your fingers are surely reaching for me. Did no sudden chill of night wake you?

(Esterke appears above on the steps, in her nightdress, startled, a candle in her hand.)

Kazimir: I am coming to you. I go... be calm, child. (turning to the pit) Do not curse me too hard, you black thing below. (He climbs up, and moves to lift her onto his shoulders and carry her into the castle.)

Esterke: do not. I beg you. The day is enough for your feats of strength; you would carry me like a toy. No — with me you shall not play the strong one. (Both go off.)

Govorek: heard that? There's more still coming to her, that Jewish maid.

Kokhan: it isn't enough for her that he loves her —

What eyes would the child have? (*folio 114*)

Govorek: it's a bad thing to lie in a pit — but no better to be a king and unable to sleep.

Kokhan: no one bade him fall in love.

Govorek: he mustn't? You're a ruler — you may do anything.

Kokhan: surely. But those eyes are foreign, not ours. If only she'd let herself be baptized. And what if he gives her a son — a king with Jewish eyes, eh? Who would trust such a one with a Christian throne? Can the blessing of the Crucified rest on a Jewish head?

Govorek: Jesus, they say, was himself a Jew; yet once our Lord was baptized, he became one of ours — so the Jewess's son too could take on our holy faith.

Kokhan: but Jesus has our eyes — Polish eyes. And Esterke's son, baptized or no, would carry two eyes dragged in from who-knows-where — eyes out of the farthest, strangest ages.

Govorek: ah... so that's your meaning? (They fall silent.)

The kitchen-maid, and the drinking (*folios 115–120*)

Kokhan (breaking the hush): too quiet, isn't it? And the night — too long. (a yawn) If only the kitchen-maid would come now — Zvonka.

Govorek: I'll run and wake her this instant. What — you're hungry, Kokhan? Go on, cook yourself up a little love.

Kokhan: she promised to come, like last night and the night before — and now nothing's seen or heard of her.

Govorek: because she's cold, the cat — no wish to crawl down from her warm bed.

Kokhan: you know what? The cook's hand is in this. He guards her with seven doglike eyes.

Govorek: no fool, that one. Wants her for himself. (Quiet.)

Kokhan: what can this be — the dogs have gone quiet a while now. (A dark figure of a woman in a shawl appears.)

Govorek: there — you have her!

Kokhan: who? Zvonka?!

Zvonka: no — not me.

Kokhan: not you — but that voice of yours. Let the little kitten sit down here between me and Govorek, and fancy that two tomcats are sitting.

Zvonka (sitting): between two tomcats, halberds in hand — one poor little cat.

Kokhan: let the kitten not be frightened; the tomcats are gentle.

Zvonka: and when the cook comes?

Kokhan: who — that lout? The wet rooster, the long nose? We have halberds, kitten.

Govorek: a cook — and he can't so much as fry up a decent kiss.

Kokhan: one ought to take his heart, lay it on a pan, and see if it cooks.

Zvonka: and have you wine, my tomcats?

Kokhan: wine to top the wine? You young ones are water!

Zvonka: it's cold, my tomcats — the kitten wants a drink. (Above, the cook appears.)

Zvonka (nestling in fright to Kokhan and Govorek): Wenceslaus?

Cook: what's the wonder? It's me — the cook.

Zvonka: if you're Wents, then I'm not here. This is no Zvonka.

Cook: then who?

Zvonka: not me.

Kokhan: come down, little brother. You'll get a third of Zvonka.

Govorek: she's not yours alone, chicken-fryer — not yours alone.

Cook (coming down): hush — no uproar... keep her, and welcome to her... I'm not after her... who needs her?

Kokhan: what then, you addled rooster-head, are you after — if not Zvonka?

Cook (slyly): what do I seek? One can't sleep. It came to me that good fellows sit up a whole night in the king's service — so why should I lie idle? I came — and not empty-handed: from the king's own cellars I've carried up wine.

Zvonka: wine?

Govorek: what are you so pleased about? He stole it from our king. Well — will you hold your tongue about him, Kokhan?

Kokhan: for such a scoundrel — shall I keep quiet? (to the cook) so — that dribble of dishwater, thief? Something good?

Cook: from Hungary, who knows how old —

Zvonka: me too — a drop for me too, Wents.

Cook: the devil take you, wench. May he sit you on his tail and ride off with you into Gehenna. You too? But you're not here at all, you said.

Zvonka: are you blind to all your own charms? Don't you see?

Cook: I see... yes, yes... now I truly see everything...

Kokhan: so — do we drink, little brothers?

Cook: one drinks.

Zvonka: we drink.

Cook: well — and you, Govorek?

Govorek: give me a little. A head can still be turned — and we, you one cook, we're meant to keep watch. We're courtyard-guards, understand? Not cooks by the fire-pan.

Zvonka: fine folk you are, Govorek — I like the cook better than you already. He who doesn't crave the drink craves nothing else either.

Kokhan: something better, you mean — (to Govorek) are you not ashamed? She likes him better still, the cook, the little kitchen-lad.

Cook (bitterly): even me — hm — even me —

Govorek: well, all right — let it be drunk. But remember: we're on watch, Kokhan. No? We keep our heads.

Kokhan: of course we're guarding. He says not!

Cook: then guard! And now — drink! (pouring) Drink, Zvonka! You are here after all — so drink.

Zvonka: surely I'm here. And truly right here — not behind your oven, Wents.

Kokhan (to the cook): and you?

Cook (a wave of the hand): eh, nothing — I've drunk already. Sip! (Kokhan, Govorek and Zvonka drink; the cook keeps pouring, but drinks none himself.)

Zvonka (sticking out her tongue at the cook, singsong): there was, at King Kazimir's, a cook with him; a cook he had — and to the cook came ruin. (Laughter.)

Kokhan: yes — a ruin. A-dyokh-yokh, brother cook.

Govorek: a ruin of all ruins to the cook of all cooks.

Zvonka: know what, Wents? Now I'm gone again. (Drunken laughter.)

A voice from above: already?

Cook: a moment! (to the three)

The coup: the cook's death (*folios 121–123*)

Govorek: what — drink again? Better to sleep — (his head sags heavily).

Zvonka (sinking down): sleep... rock me, Kokhan... sleep...

Kokhan: sleep... (The three drift off, propped against one another.)

Cook (stretching, eyeing the sleeping Zvonka): whore-maid! Unclean flesh! In the dead of night she crawls to Kokhan — and an honest cook is left behind. (He rifles through Kokhan and Govorek, finds the key to the iron pit-cover.) With this, my little pikes, we'll open the lid. (calling upward) All ready!

(Dark shapes steal down the steps — Matshko Barkovitsh, armed knights behind him, bearing sacks, ropes, irons, a ladder.)

Cook (pointing at the sleepers): does the voivode see? They sleep like the dead — a maid in the midst of them. Like dogs. Like unbelieving Tatars.

Barkovitsh: don't boast. It's unbolted.

Cook: I say nothing... but I wonder... why should a maid like that — (he breaks off) but Kokhan and Govorek — they'll earn themselves a black end for such guarding.

Barkovitsh: the lock, here! We did not come to hear a cook's prattle.

Cook (handing it over): you, girl, will be found tomorrow between these two. And the pit — an empty one... once again an honest cook did not betray. (he moves to go)

Barkovitsh (barring his way): where to?

Cook: good night. Not slept out, voivode.

Barkovitsh: soon we'll lay you down to sleep; you'll not leave this place, dear man.

Cook: I don't understand.

Barkovitsh: so you won't blab it all out tomorrow. We know your kind, boors.

Cook: I helped the lord. I want to go and sleep.

Barkovitsh: thanks for your help. But you must help to the very end.

Barkovitsh: you must let yourself be killed. (to a knight) Stab him! Quick!

Cook (in mortal terror): why? why?

The knight: my hand is trembling.

Barkovitsh: no talk! Stab!

(The knight stabs the cook.)

Cook (falling): Zvonka...

Barkovitsh: let him lie. A faithful man he was. He helped. (bending over the opened pit) Father Baritshka! Father Baritshka! We've come to set you free — a good Christian speaks, Matshko Barkovitsh.

Baritshka's voice: I know the voice —

Barkovitsh: then know the heart as well. I've come to save you. Here's a ladder. Quick — quick.

Baritshka's voice: praised be Jesus Christ —

Barkovitsh (piously):

Baritshka smothered; the voivode claims the crown (*folios 124–127*)

Barkovitsh: — in all eternities. (The ladder goes down; Baritshka, grown ragged, hands and feet shaking, crawls limply out, glances about, crosses himself.)

Baritshka: wonders you work, Jesus, for your faithful.

Barkovitsh and the knights (piously): Amen.

Barkovitsh: and now — into the sack, father, into the sack.

Baritshka: why into a sack?

Barkovitsh: it must be so, father — it must. Such is the plan. (The knights begin forcing him into a sack.) You've rope — draw it tight! Do you hear? Tight!

Baritshka: I'm being choked. Why the rope, you Christians?

Barkovitsh: you're a holy man, and God will not suffer you to be strangled just now, when my own men are rescuing you.

Baritshka: why draw it tight? Jesus, help! What are you doing?

Barkovitsh: it must be done — must be. So none may catch what — and whom — we carry here. (to the knights) Drawn tight already?

(Baritshka gives a last rattle; silence falls.)

Barkovitsh: strangled, eh? And who is to blame? King Kazimir! It is all for his sake, and hers — his Jewish girl, the fair calamity of Opotshne. Were he not king, and she his concubine — would we have throttled a holy Christian? No; we'd have done no such thing. So then: he — Kazimierz — he and Estera — *they* are guilty! They! All Poland shall know it!

The knights: he is guilty — and his concubine, the Jewish daughter. Poland shall know.

Barkovitsh: now take him, the holy one, out of the sack, and lay him a moment where the cook-boy lies. (It is done.) I want to look into the sack. I want to see. (stooping over the empty sack the knights hold open) On the mouth of this sack there glints a crown for me — the crown of Poland. Mark it, all of you: you shall walk clothed in gold with me; you'll see — in gold — you need only obey. (a pause) You see? Daybreak is near. The castle — (gazing at the royal castle paling in the distance) — the castle shall be mine. This night a new ruler is born: I, the voivode of Great Poland.

Barkovitsh: two deaths, one birth in this one night. And now — take the sack from me and lay him, the father, back inside it. (The knights return the body to the sack.) Two deaths, eh? What do you say, Lekh — you're a shrewd one.

Lekh: two. Surely.

Barkovitsh: you're certain? He too a man — the cook?

Lekh: he too. Surely.

Barkovitsh: you lie. Say no.

Lekh: I think — yes. A good cook he was.

Barkovitsh: yes, he helped, you say — two? (he crosses himself) And he — Kazimir's father, Łokietek — did he spill so little blood? A crown is blood.

Lekh: may the Crucified shield us.

Barkovitsh: drag the cook here too, the foolish one. I've a word for him — and will he hear it now!

Barkovitsh: drag, and ask nothing, old man.

(Lekh drags the cook's body, groaning.)

Barkovitsh (over the body): so, you cook... you royal cook... one thrust, and the cook's undone. A man? Lekh says a man. But you may understand that I am a lord who is to become king. So — forgive me. (over the sack where Baritshka's body lies) Ha! You didn't come back to life, didn't spring up of a sudden, didn't lay us like dead snakes at your feet? (a pause; he looks at the greying east and crosses himself in a heathen dread) You, daybreak — you come even after such a night? Knights, come! Steal away! In the heavens there is no one; and if there is — he's like one of us. (shuffling off quietly with his men.)

(The three — Kokhan, Govorek, Zvonka — sleep on; the poisoned dogs lie still; the castle sleeps. Back from the castle come quietly Pastekhl, the good dream, and Zkndl, the bad.)

Pastekhl: ah, how I fooled her, the girl from Opotshne... I lulled her with ticklish follies... whole herds of jests

Netsiel's lullaby — end of Act II (*folios 128–129*)

Pastekhl: — I set out to graze... I stood on my head... I piped straight into Esterke's very heart.

Zkndl: and I showed her her father, Yerukhem... and the king I showed her as Łokietek...

Pastekhl: out of my sight. I am young — and I'll stick my tongue out at you.

Zkndl: rascal-boy! Will you never stop cracking that whip?

Pastekhl (chasing Zkndl off, turning a somersault, rising wet with the dawn-dew, dancing away into the bushes).

Netsiel (entering, fanning with his shadow-staff, gazing to the castle windows, softly singing): *sleep, sleep, Esterke. I — I come striding out of Poland's black forests, its mist-grey meadows. Evil years, in their hundreds, I'll pace out here, until I will, until I will stride away from here — and never once return, after so many generations! I know not why — only that such is the Creator's command.*

Netsiel: I know not what he wants — I know not, yet I trust him. Troubles I must bear here at the hands of the worst of gentiles — (a short pause) sleep, sleep, Esterke; dawn will soon break. One day I'll go, and carry off with me, my little sister, troubles bundle upon bundle, whole skirtfuls of grief — exile, exile, exile. (Curtain.)

ACT III

Esterke's castle at Łobzów

The hidden queen and her lost son (folios 129–131)

Setting: Esterke's castle at Łobzów; from somewhere church-bells drift into a still, clouded day. Esterke and Levko in the castle garden.

Esterke: Kazimir has set me down here in loneliness. The cave — hidden among the trees and sealed with a stone — brings him to me by stealth and leads him back again; and rare is my joy, and short. You know how his enemies put it about that it was *he* who had Baritshka killed, and that I, the Jewess, talked him into it; that I myself was egged on by my people, the enemy of their God. Ever since, I sit hidden away — and my child... where is my son, my Pelko, whom I bore to the king of Poland? He himself, the boy's own father, was forced to have him sent off to some cloister. Do you hear the bells? I shudder whenever a cloister rings — it is my Pelko weeping to me. Why so silent, Levko? Had my father's blood at least been avenged — but not even that was granted me.

Levko: no — not even that. Pashko fled to Hungary the moment the king's enemies warned him that the king himself was shielding you. But what can the king do? He's a merciful king — yet a king only over gentiles. Should he go into hiding with you? Who then would rule the realm, Esterke?

Esterke: what is his realm to me? I love only *him*, not a king. Who has need of kings? What is a crown? Why should I be forbidden to love a man for the one reason that he is called Kazimir and is king over Poland?

Levko: a child you are, still a child. It is *I*, Levko, who am to blame — I have sinned! I dreamed of a second Esther, who would rise to shield us when the hatred grew strong. What my brothers grasped at once, the dream would not let me see. A fool I was — oh, what a fool! I never understood that you could be only the king's concubine, never a queen in a Christian land — and unbaptized at that. The dream blinded my eyes to the truth: that between you, Esther daughter of Yerukhem, and a Kazimir son of Łokietek, lie the abysses of the generations. I ought to have snatched you from the king's gaze. I did not catch myself in time — that if the king gives you a son, he'll be a bastard, uncircumcised —

Esterke: you call my Pelko a bastard?

Levko: yes — how else? A dread has crept into the people, that in time a Jew might come to rule them; even Yan Sukhivilk is no longer the man he was. Let Pelko be reared in a cloister, and even come to hate the Jewish people —

Two apparitions (folio 132)

Levko: — for to them he is the son of Christ's murderers. They imagine that we, the bearers of God's tablets, stand ready to murder them — and so they ready themselves to murder us first. What can you understand of all this? You're only a child, only an Esterke. And what am I? A fool, a Levko-fool —

(A Jew with a little sack on his shoulders appears.) **The Jew with the sack:** from the crucifixes where they keep me hanging, I have climbed down. Romans once crucified me; ever since, the gentiles crucify me, torment me and my brothers without end. I'm a plain Jew — with a sack on my back I let myself trade from village to village. I fear only the village-dogs, that they not tear me by the coat-hem. Help me, dear God! (He vanishes.)

The ghost of Esterke's father: my house is burned, and I with it; burned is my inn. My child has strayed off among the gentiles, and I wander the waste — woe to me! Woe and desolation... My child has borne the gentile king a child — (He vanishes.)

The king in the garden; Łokietek's ghost (folios 133–134)

(The stone before the cave is pushed aside from within; out steps, quietly, and crosses to Esterke and Levko — the king, Kazimir.)

Kazimir: good it is to see you, Levko. She is lonely, and needs a man of her own people. (to Esterke, who watches him in silence) Today, before dawn, at the hunt, your image danced for me among the trees. I ran after it and began to lose my way. A fresh wild scent filled my nostrils; the forest played out your name. Eyes shut, I listened to the blare of the horns and set off after the sound — to find a path to my own. And it seemed to me: it is not the hunting-horns that call... *you* call — and I come...

Esterke: speak not of the hunt — it is the blood-sport of the strong.

Kazimir: the forest, the whole forest, was fragrant with your hair.

Esterke: speak not of the forest... do not! My father's inn stood by a forest; when Pashko the village-lord rode out to hunt, the sun would die in our window, the dogs bayed, and the horns bayed with them.

Esterke: the inn trembled. Speak not of the hunt, nor of the forest — those are the words of the strong.

Levko (half to himself): not an Esther — only an Esterke... a little bird in winter...

Kazimir: the forest wore the look of a green cloister. Through the cloister, through its green, I came to you — to Esterke.

Esterke: speak not of forest, hunt, or cloister. You let Pelko be sent to a cloister.

Kazimir (his head bowed): I had to.

Levko: have you heard, my king — that Esterke's hiding place is discovered?

Kazimir: I know it, Levko. That is why I came. Let the three of us go into the castle for now. (All three go off.)

(A riders' gallop, far off; a moment of stillness. Then along the road comes a small-statured figure, a crown upon its head, looking and listening — the ghost of old King Łokietek.) **Łokietek:** Poland, ring out — I have come.

The two hosts converge (folios 135–139)

Łokietek: where are you? Your crowned one calls. Death has laid chains on my hands. Take up the sword, and with the sword strike my chains away. This is I — Łokietek. (The gallop is heard anew.) At the head of my crown Poland's trees rise up and sing: hail to you, lord of Poland. Where is my son, my Kazimierz! (Off.)

(The gallop nears; riders dismount; before the castle, a tumult. Two hosts — one led by Barkovitsh, the other by Chancellor Yan Sukhivilk with Wierzzsinek and Spitek.)

Barkovitsh: Kazimir's shame is laid bare! He keeps her here — hides her! Bring out the concubine!

Wierzzsinek: we may not harm a hair of her head. The king hid her from us — now we'll hide her away *for* him; that is all. Why do you shout?

Spitek: against sorcery not even the greatest man is proof, szlachta. Of what is the king guilty? And she too — Estera is not guilty: she belongs to the sorcerer-folk, a spell is in her; we need only remove her from our Christian king, no more. She did belong to the king. Take the spell from him, and he'll be Łokietek's son once more — he'll lead us to battle for Poland's glory, and the bright sword will guard the houses he raises.

Sukhivilk: be still — for all this is done in the name of the law. Peace wills it, and the will of the land, that Esterke the Jewess — guilty or innocent — be parted from the king. For that alone am I here too, the servant of Poland and of Kazimir. Calmly and with deliberation must all this be done that is done for Poland's will, which is one with the will of her great ruler.

Barkovitsh: ruler? Great? Great by what measure? Is he not, this ruler of yours, guilty of the death of Christ's good servant, the holy Baritshka? And his concubine — does she not spring from those who slew Christ; did she not goad your ruler, did she not strengthen his evil hand? For Baritshka's holy blood, you szlachta!

A knight (of Matshko's men): for Baritshka's holy blood!

(Others of his men waver and cross quietly to Sukhivilk's side.)

Sukhivilk (to Barkovitsh): you savage firebrand! You traitor!

Barkovitsh: when *I* am Poland's king — ha, what say you, szlachta — would I have stained my hands with the blood of Christ's servant? Would I too have killed him because he would not stomach my malice, because he punished me for my deeds? What say you, szlachta?

Wierzzsinek: when *you* become Poland's ruler, voivode — then I'll go into my treasury, take every good from the chests, fling it to the swine of my own court, and fling myself into the Vistula after it — die, Wierzzsinek!

Barkovitsh: die, then! Die with your king! For when I am Poland's king — ha — would I have such statutes drawn up as Kazimir did at Wiślica? No — I'd have kept the old knight-law. I would —

Sukhivilk: have you forgotten who stands here? Bethink yourself: Sukhivilk! A tongue like yours could cost you — know what? A head.

Barkovitsh: we've no fear. Brothers, szlachta — who needs Yan here? What's he doing here? Off to Kraków with him! To Wiślica! Law! Statutes! (laughing) Now *we* are the kings, is it not so! (with lust) Bring here the wench of Opotshne!

Sukhivilk: fair she is, and pure, you scab, you Matshko. You'll not defile her, beast.

Barkovitsh: a fair one — the like never seen? A pure one, in a world where blood is right, where blood is crown, where a man is born in blood and killed in blood? Here with the woman! After me!

Sukhivilk: vermin's blood! Hold him! Seize the devil — (Barkovitsh's knights draw and rush the king-loyal castle; Sukhivilk, Spitek, Wierzzsinek and others bar the passages.) Over my body! Fall back! Back!

(Barkovitsh's men, disheartened, begin to draw back.)

Barkovitsh: why do you heed him? Who is he?

Sukhivilk: we'll call her out — will we not — bow, and tell her what we wish. With reverence we'll do it, my lords. What the lord holds dear, his servants must honor.

Barkovitsh: we honor no king, and we serve neither him nor Yan.

(There appear the king and Levko — Levko leading Esterke by the hand.)

Kazimir (in anger): so it is you, Barkovitsh!

Barkovitsh: does he need you? (to his men) whoever is with Matshko — strike!

Voices: for Baritshka's blood — strike!

Levko (to Matshko): you forest-swine! One ought to split your skull —

Barkovitsh: hack him to pieces — chop up the Jew, the Levko!

Sukhivilk (half to the king, half to the crowd): right is turned to revolt! The welfare of the land —

The battle; Barkovitsh bound (*folios 140–141*)

Sukhivilk: — into an uprising against the land! Sword against sword, and doom for Matshko — strike!

Barkovitsh's men: for Yan — doom! For Matshko — a crown!

Barkovitsh: the Jewish maid, here! And after — Kazimir, Kazimir too!

Barkovitsh's men: whoever's for Matshko — cut them down!

Barkovitsh: remember — Brandenburg too is on Matshko's side. Don't look — cut! And for the crown — a reward! (to the king and Sukhivilk) it is over with you!

Other knights: a reward? Here's your reward, mutiny!

Sukhivilk: loyal ones, to your swords! Revolt —

Wierzszinek (to Barkovitsh): mad dog — conspirator — dog —

Spitek: for the king! Throw them to the ground! (A clash of swords; wounded knights on the earth; Sukhivilk's host overpowers Matshko Barkovitsh's.)

(Levko runs to Barkovitsh and wrenches the sword from his hand.)

Kazimir: bind Barkovitsh!

(The king-loyal bind him.)

Barkovitsh (wildly): whom do you bind? *Me?* (he finds himself lashed to a tree, ringed by the guard) Above the tree — a heaven. I, below the tree. Heaven — I — a tree between. Where am I now, my lords?

Voices of his men: Matshko has fallen! Run! (Some flee.)

Sukhivilk: now let him be king! Now, voivode — rule!

A voice (from Barkovitsh's men): don't run! Beg pardon of the king and of Yan!

Another voice: flee? Can we leave the dead behind?

Barkovitsh: cowards! Fight! Cut me loose! Why do you gape!

Sukhivilk: straw! (to the king) forgive your servants. And forgive that you find me here.

Kazimir: what are my servants doing among robbers?

Sukhivilk: they held the robbers back from their robbery, drove off those who meant to steal —

"You must take leave"; Lekh's dying confession (*folios 142–144*)

Sukhivilk: — the king's might and honor and his treasure, Estera; they bound revolt and wrong. But —

Kazimir: I hear you.

Sukhivilk: brother-blood has stained the ground before your heart's-beloved's castle, my king.

(Kazimir is silent.)

Sukhivilk: you must take your leave, king.

Kazimir: you, Sukhivilk — you say it?

Sukhivilk (firmly): in the name of the land.

Kazimir: you mean it so?

Sukhivilk: you see it yourself, my lord.

Kazimir (half under his breath): I see.

Sukhivilk: we will bow before Estera, lead her off to some other castle, a far, far one, and give her guards and servants — all her heart could wish; from heaven, the gold of the stars; the silver of the Vistula's waves — and the finest wines; we'll fill her bedchamber with the scents of spices, with winds that lull; we'll bring her the moon's golden head for a gift, and give her everything that flies through the forests of thought — all, save you. You we need for ourselves — we need you for Poland. (Silence.)

Kazimir (resigned): through you speaks Poland. Yes — I have heard. It is not one man that speaks so — it is a whole people. It is injustice — but not of one man; of an entire people, Yan.

An old knight (of Barkovitsh's host, stretched on the ground, dying): I am dying... I want... I must... I must tell... that...

Sukhivilk (drawing near him): what would you say? That you die as fools die — for the sake of a Barkovitsh?

Barkovitsh (to the dying man): Lekh — you're dying anyway... so say nothing... die! Baritshka did not come back to life that night, and God kept silent. You be silent too. Perish — and hold your tongue.

Lekh: God speaks through men... now through me... know this: Barkovitsh had Matshko strangled... and, at one stroke, the cook that night as well... he had them stabbed... and Baritshka's blood he laid upon the king and the Jewess... forgive, Jesus... forgive... (He dies.)

Kazimir: murderers have laid their heavy guilt upon me and her. My lords — you believed it. With iron one must rule over you —

Sukhivilk: — and with justice —

Spitek: oh, and with a war to crown it!

Sukhivilk: I raise my hand and swear in Poland's name: all the Matshkos must be wiped out.

Barkovitsh: the Sukhivilks must be wiped out.

Wierzszinek: the Barkovitshes must be wiped out.

Spitek: but why does Levko keep silent? And why does Estera keep silent?

Esterke chooses Opotshne (*folio 145*)

Kazimir: there must be something in your silence, Levko — I want to know what you are turning over.

Levko: it was a dream — and the dream deceived them both: Poland's great ruler and the Jewish girl of Opotshne. That is what I turn over.

Esterke (to Kazimir): before my words could become words, they would turn to kisses; before my kisses could become kisses, they would turn to tears. But no — I must not weep. (to Sukhivilk) Sukhivilk, I have heard your speech. I need no hiding-places — none. I will not wander from castle to castle. To Opotshne I will go. On the ruins of my father's inn I will stand; there I will have a prayer-house built, and there they will say kaddish for my father. And I myself — what will become of me? I do not know. I am going away. I will go, and I do not care if I perish on the road. Come with me, Levko. (Both go off. A deep silence.)

EPILOGUE

the ruins at Opotshne

"I stand upon what-was" (*folio 146*)

Setting: the ruins of Yerukhem's inn in Opotshne; a secret, still, star-strewn night.

Esterke: here once stood my house. Here once was my mother — who brought me into the world, and then went off into another world. Here once was my father. Here there was, there was... and I too once was. I am a woman-who-was. I stand upon what-once-was, Levko.

Levko: someone stirs there among the ruins — do you see? Hey — come here, you man! Say: where are you looking? Or rather — into *what*?

A madman: I look into two things that are one: into what has been, and into what will yet come to pass, who-knows-when. I see fires, conflagrations each greater than the last. It burns — the inn burns. Forever the inn burns. Beams crack, and doors, and walls... In the inn the Jew is burned, and, burning, he walks, and walks, and walks...

Esterke: my fingers draw away from my hands —

The poets on the ruins (*folios 147–148*)

Esterke: — to kindle the Sabbath candles.

Levko (to the madman, who is pointing at a shadow): who is that one?

The madman: out of the not-yet, out of generations still to come... he walks through Poland's night, seeking something, saying something...

Peretz: Poland — your night and mine have grown into one. Spin, you doubled night, spin! Grow thin enough that through your very entrails I might hear, in Yiddish, the voice of the world. (a pause) No — I am deceived! Poland's night, you drive me, you hound me. I must go from here. I am not of this place, no. I must go — I must go — (a second shadow comes to meet him.)

Mickiewicz: my father — of Edom; my mother — of the Jews; and my name — Adam — is still, for now, only *dam* [blood].

Peretz: from the Frankists you come — four-and-forty you are named. You too must go — where do you go?

Mickiewicz: four-and-forty⁴ I am named. *Dam* — and the aleph is missing.

⁴ Footnote in the source — a quotation from Mickiewicz's *Great Improvisation*: "of a foreign mother, ancient heroes' blood his blood, and his name — four-and-forty."

Peretz: who *you* are, that I know; yet who *I* am, you do not know... of your mother's people!

Mickiewicz: Adam is still dam... Adam is still dam...

Peretz: you wander too...

Mickiewicz: as you do... Poland's night hunts me as well. They set me up — "stand with us, be a monument" — but I cannot stand among them; I must go from here. I am not of this place, no. I must go, must go.

The Jew with the sack: I too must go. I am not of this place, no. They hung me up —

"Let us all go"; Netsiel's song, and the end (*folios 149–150*)

The Jew with the sack: — crucifixes crucify me. I go down, to go to the true Messiah, to the far end of days.

Yerukhem: I go, I go — let us all go! Esterke, come with me!

Esterke: let us all go, all go — father, I come with you!

Levko: let us go, all of us, all — with the selfsame step — (to the madman) well, and you — and you?

The madman: take back from me your clever eyes — it is from the troubles of the Jews that I am mad. Of course I go! I follow the scent of Jewish burnings — trayf is she, trayf is the world — at the altar, above, Michael the prince awaits me, who offers up souls to God our Lord. (He listens.)

The madman: hush — a guest! The Eternal Jew! How goes it, Netsiel? Sing me a song...

Netsiel (leaning on his shadow-staff, gazing into the distance, singing softly):
Ko-lin! Po-lin! So runs the decree — here you must lodge the night; you must. Why? In the somewheres it is known. And one day, when the night takes to nighting with a devilish, unimagined power — then afterward there will be an end of Po-lin. And in Jerusalem a dawn will rise, and to Jerusalem they will go; to Jerusalem they will go.

(End.) — Reworked version, 1967.

NOTES

names, places & terms

These notes are the digest editor's, for the reader's convenience — distinct from the four footnotes carried over from the printed source (whose authorship is unverified). The play reshapes history freely; dates and identifications are approximate.

People

Łokietek — Władysław I "the Elbow-high" (r. 1320–1333), who reunited the fragmented Polish kingdom; Casimir's father. His sword, his "son," and his ghost recur through the play.

Kazimir — Casimir III "the Great" (r. 1333–1370), the last Piast king — lawgiver, builder in stone, and protector of the Jews; the Esterke legend attaches to him.

Aldona — Aldona-Anna of Lithuania, Casimir's pagan-born first wife ("the Lithuanian heathen").

Adelaida — Adelheid of Hesse, his long-estranged second wife: the queen of the play.

Klara — an echo of the Klára Zách scandal at the Hungarian court (1330), recast here as a seduction by Casimir.

Bodzanta — the church prelate in whose name the priest Baritshka confronts the king.

Mickiewicz — Adam Mickiewicz (1798–1855), Poland's national poet. The "Great Improvisation" is a celebrated monologue in his *Forefathers' Eve*; "forty-four" its cryptic messianic figure. His mother was reputedly of Frankist descent — hence "from the Frankists you come," and the pun *Adam* (אדם) minus its aleph = *dam* (דם), "blood."

Peretz — I. L. Peretz (1852–1915), a founder of modern Yiddish literature; in the epilogue, a shade straining to hear "the voice of the world in Yiddish."

Netsiel — Zeitlin's name (from *netsakh*, "eternity") for the Wandering / Eternal Jew, the deathless witness who haunts the play like a one-man chorus.

Peoples, titles & institutions

Piast — Poland's founding dynasty; Casimir was its last king — which is why the want of an heir so haunts the court.

Teutonic Knights ("the Order of the Cross," "the Germans") — the German crusading order at war with Poland; the play's off-stage enemy.

Avignon — seat of the papacy (1309–1377), where Poland's foes carry their complaints.

Bolesław of Kalisz — Bolesław the Pious, whose Statute of Kalisz (1264) gave the Jews legal protection; Casimir renewed and broadened it.

Frankists — followers of the 18th-c. messianic apostate Jacob Frank, many of whom converted and entered the Polish gentry.

szlachta — the Polish nobility as a class. **voivode** — a provincial governor / warlord (Barkovitsh's self-styled rank). **landgrave** — a German count (Adelaida's father).

Places

Wiślica — where Casimir's law-statutes were promulgated; shorthand for his legal reforms.

Wawel — the royal castle and hill at Kraków, seat of the kings (Baritshka's curse, "ruin on you, Wawel").

Łobzów — a royal manor near Kraków, linked by legend to Esterke.

Opoczno (*Opotshne*) — the central-Polish town the legendary Esterke comes from.

Po-lin — the folk etymology of "Poland" as Hebrew *po lin*, "here shall you lodge": the exiles hear the words as a heavenly sign to settle. The play's governing image.

Legend & Jewish words

Esterke — the legendary Jewish beloved of Casimir the Great, mother (in the tale) of his children; a figure of Polish and Jewish folklore, with no firm historical basis.

melekh — king · **mamzer** — a child of a forbidden union, loosely "bastard" · **trayf** — ritually unclean, non-kosher · **kaddish** — the mourner's prayer ("to say kaddish for" = to mourn as a child does a parent) · **Gehenna** — hell · **acharit ha-yamim** — the "end of days," the messianic end-time.

Paraphrase complete: Acts I–III and the Epilogue, folios 81–150. This digest is the editor's own retelling — each speaker in their own voice — written to carry the play's temper without reproducing its copyrighted text.